



Networking to Build Your Business

As the owner of a start-up, you need to make connections so that your business becomes better known and builds some support. As your business grows, these connections may become mutually beneficial relationships.

Meeting in person

Online technology provides plenty of good ways to connect, and video-conferencing platforms have come into their own since the global pandemic. Apps such as Zoom, Microsoft Teams, Google Hangout, and Skype offer facilities for people around the world to see each other in real time, host meetings, share visuals, and vote on decisions.

However, where possible, face-to-face contact, especially when meeting someone for the first time, is an easier way to establish a rapport with someone. A significant part of communication is body language; being able to see and

interpret a person's reactions helps both understanding and the flow of conversation. It is also a better way to build credibility and establish trust.

Face-to-face networking need not be daunting. Think about it as a way to gain personal exposure, which will create opportunities and grow the business. Set a goal to meet more people, have meaningful interactions, and build personal and professional relationships. Look for professional networking events as well as special interest groups and associations linked to your area of business where you can go along and make connections.

Maintaining relationships

Networking is not just about seeking out new contacts. Imagine two lists. The first is your target list, containing people to get to know, or types of people to connect with, for example, influencers in your sector. The second list contains all your current contacts. Choose the relationships to maintain and strengthen, and plan to have a weekly coffee or phone call with at least one of these people. Do not assume anything; asking open questions may reveal connections. Always aim to help contacts as far as possible, even if it is just emailing a link to an article.

HOW TO NETWORK EFFECTIVELY

There are some important ways in which you can make your face-to-face networking more successful.

- **Dress appropriately.**
- **Listen carefully** to the people you meet to find shared interests. Then, politely move on to meet others.
- **Aim to develop relationships** rather than sell something.
- **Exchange a well-designed business card** with people you want to connect with.
- **Follow up** with an email or connection via social media.



MAKING IT WORK

- **Nurture and maintain** your current contacts by staying in touch, but do not add people to your email list without their permission.
- **Trust remains** the basis of any relationship, so be sure to follow through on any offers to share information that you make when you meet someone.
- **Inform your contacts** when you are launching a new product or service and seek input from those with relevant experience.